



willing to come and play there, so I decided to put my money and get the thing sorted. I did it," he says.

Today, that viewing gallery is known as the Sir Dickie Bird Players' Balcony. He makes it a point to attend every match played at Headingley, whether international or domestic. Earlier this year, during the opening match of the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy, Bird was there daily — watching cricket, catching up with old friends like Sunil Gavaskar and Roger Binny.

Though his days around the game have slowed, his connection to cricket remains strong. At home, much of his time is devoted to the Dickie Bird Foundation, which supports underprivileged children. Large portions of his savings have been donated to fund medical care for those in need, distributed through local hospitals.

"I have been doing it for years, and that gives me immense joy," he says. Partway through our conversation, Bird reflects on his nickname.

"The nickname 'Dickie' was given to me at school. The Whites were 'Chalkie', all the Clarks were 'Nobby', and all the Birds were 'Dickie'," he says with a smile, adding that his friend Tommy Taylor, a former international footballer, became 'Tucker' and was referred to as Little Tommy Tucker.

From there, the memories come flooding in. He recalls the time he was invited to Buckingham Palace for lunch with the Queen.

"The Palace office called me to check if I could come and meet her, and I told the gentleman that I could walk all the way from Barnsley to London to meet the Queen," Bird says. "I got to spend the whole day, have lunch at Buckingham Palace, and it was a great experience..."

These moments still make him light up. Bird also maintains a personal archive of newspaper clippings.

"I have been doing it since the age of 14, and even now, I read the newspapers and keep clippings of all the interesting stories and

Royal honour: Dickie Bird beams with his OBE, awarded by Prince Charles at Buckingham Palace for services to cricket and charity. GETTY IMAGES

whatever they write about me," he says. After a brief pause, he adds, "You must send me the clipping of the story when it gets published... I'll add them to my collection..."

Cricket books and daily newspapers help fill the hours. And now and then, Bird picks up the phone to call Boycott or a few other old mates for conversations about cricket and life in general.

Cricket once gave him wings. It still keeps him afloat.

And when he's alone at home, in his four-bedroom cottage overlooking the Pennines, life may feel quiet—even solitary. But he rises from the couch, takes a walk, jogs through the garden, and reads the cricket section in the paper. Suddenly, everything feels a little lighter. A little more like itself.

Life, again, is beautiful.